the discussions they had had before it exploded about the prohibition of nuclear tests.[6]

Kennedy's letter dealt with the open or public side of the deal. He would probably have preferred to forget about the offer he had passed through Robert to Dobrynin the previous evening, but Khrushchev was there to remind him about it. Dobrynin called Robert that morning, requesting a meeting. Robert Kennedy recalled that instead of going to church that morning, he had taken his three daughters to a horse show at the Washington Armory. It was there, around 10:00 a.m., that he received a phone call from Dean Rusk informing him about Khrushchev's acceptance of President Kennedy's offer. Robert rushed to the White House, where he took the call from Dobrynin. They agreed to meet in Robert Kennedy's office at the Justice Department at 11:00 a.m.[7]

The Soviet ambassador was, as always, the last person to learn what was going on in Moscow. He complained to his bosses that their instructions had arrived approximately an hour and a half after American radio had broadcast the essence of Khrushchev's response. Dobrynin did not yet have either the text of the public letter to Kennedy or Khrushchev's private note to the president concerning the Turkey-Cuba deal. What he had to guide him instead was Gromyko's message, sent from Moscow about 4:00 p.m. local time, instructing him to get in touch with Robert Kennedy immediately and tell him that Moscow was appreciative of what he had had to say to Dobrynin the previous night, and that the response to his brother's offer would be positive. Consequently, the ambassador headed to the Justice Department with yesterday's news—a message telling Robert that a letter to his brother was in the making. By then, its substance was all over the airwaves.

When they met, Dobrynin explained the obsolescence of his message by problems at the telegraph station. Robert was happy nevertheless to receive confirmation of the news he had already learned at the White House. It was the first time in several weeks that Dobrynin saw him smiling. "This is a great relief," Kennedy told the ambassador, who noted in his subsequent report to Moscow that "it was evident that he expressed his words somehow involuntarily." Gromyko's message implied that the offer passed to Dobrynin by Robert the previous night was largely responsible for